

The Adventure of the Speckled Band

Arthur Conan Doyle · 1892

First published: The Strand, Feb 1892

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

AP edition (standards shown for this framework only)

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

Liber et Libri · Lux et Libri LLC

Cover: Jean-Honoré Fragonard, A Young Girl Reading (c. 1770). Public domain (Wikimedia Commons).

Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson 1: introduction (author, context, reception, overview)
4. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
5. Unit test (eleven rigor versions) with answer keys and scoring guides
6. Final paper
7. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Adventures_of_Sherlock_Holmes_(1892,_US)/The_Adventure_of_the_Speckled_Band (revision 15104245), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 7–11 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 2 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does The Adventure of the Speckled Band suggest about reason and deduction?
- What does The Adventure of the Speckled Band suggest about greed and violence?
- What does The Adventure of the Speckled Band suggest about protection of the vulnerable?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards: AP

AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN

AP English Literature and Composition big ideas (our summaries; apcentral.collegeboard.org)

Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five

Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	*Introduction: author, context and reception* The Adventure of the Speckled Band	2 × 90 min (180 min)	*reason and deduction* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Introduction: author, context and reception • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Introduction to The Adventure of the Speckled Band

Author biography

Arthur Conan Doyle was born in Edinburgh on 22 May 1859, studied medicine at the University of Edinburgh, where his teacher Dr. Joseph Bell's powers of observation inspired Sherlock Holmes, and practised as a doctor in Southsea. Holmes first appeared in A Study in Scarlet (1887); the stories in The Strand Magazine from 1891 made him world-famous. Doyle also wrote historical stories and science fiction, served as a volunteer doctor in the Boer War, was knighted in 1902, and in later life became a passionate Spiritualist. He died on 7 July 1930.

Historical and cultural context

Victorian England combined new forensic science with fascination with the Empire, especially India. The story's villain is a doctor who practised in Calcutta and keeps exotic animals.

Publication and reception, then and now

First published in The Strand Magazine in February 1892; collected in The Adventures of Sherlock Holmes (1892).

Then: Very popular; Doyle later named it his favourite Holmes story.

Now: A model locked-room mystery for teaching inference and clues.

Overview (spoiler-free)

Helen Stoner comes to Holmes in terror: her twin sister died mysteriously two years earlier, crying out about "the speckled band," and now Helen hears the same strange whistle at night.

Main themes

- deduction and reason.
- greed.
- violence recoils on the violent.

Why it matters

Students practise inference and learn how mysteries plant clues fairly.

Spoilers · teacher only

Holmes finds that the stepfather, Dr. Grimesby Roylott, sent a venomous snake through a ventilator to kill the sisters for their inheritance; the snake turns on Roylott and kills him.

Lesson plan (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)

Before we open The Adventure of the Speckled Band: What clues can you tell about a person from their appearance?
Prompt: Before we open The Adventure of the Speckled Band: What clues can you tell about a person from their appearance?

8–18 min · Key terms · I do (10 min)

locked-room mystery; red herring; clue; foreshadowing; deduction.

18–28 min · Mini-lecture: author, context, reception · I do (10 min)

About the author. Arthur Conan Doyle was born in Edinburgh on 22 May 1859, studied medicine at the University of Edinburgh, where his teacher Dr. Joseph Bell's powers of observation inspired Sherlock Holmes, and practised as a doctor in Southsea. Holmes first appeared in A Study in Scarlet (1887); the stories in The Strand Magazine from 1891 made him world-famous. Doyle also wrote historical stories and science fiction, served as a volunteer doctor in the Boer War, was knighted in 1902, and in later life became a passionate Spiritualist. He died on 7 July 1930. The world of the book. Victorian England combined new forensic science with fascination with the Empire, especially India. The story's villain is a doctor who practised in Calcutta and keeps exotic animals. Publication and reception. First published in The Strand Magazine in February 1892; collected in The Adventures of Sherlock Holmes (1892). Then: Very popular; Doyle later named it his favourite Holmes story. Now: A model locked-room mystery for teaching inference and clues.

28–40 min · I do: the book in one passage · I do (12 min)

"It is fear, Mr. Holmes. It is terror" (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 11). Helen's first words.

> *It is fear, Mr. Holmes. It is terror (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 11)*

Think-aloud: "It is fear, Mr. Holmes. It is terror" (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 11). Helen's first words.

40–55 min · We do: overview and themes · We do (15 min)

What the book is about (no spoilers): Helen Stoner comes to Holmes in terror: her twin sister died mysteriously two years earlier, crying out about "the speckled band," and now Helen hears the same strange whistle at night. Themes to track: deduction and reason.: greed.: violence recoils on the violent.:

55–70 min · You do: reading journal · You do (15 min)

Set up a reading journal: one page per theme with a prediction and a question.
Task: Set up a reading journal for The Adventure of the Speckled Band: one page per theme, each with a prediction and a question.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)

Why does The Adventure of the Speckled Band still matter? Students practise inference and learn how mysteries plant clues fairly.
Anchor question: Why might The Adventure of the Speckled Band still be taught today?
Facilitation: Students practise inference and learn how mysteries plant clues fairly.

80–87 min · Exit ticket · You do (7 min)

Name two clues that point to the snake. Answer: The bell-rope that does not ring, the ventilator, the saucer of milk, the whistle, the bed clamped to the floor.
Exit ticket: Name two clues that point to the snake.
Answer: The bell-rope that does not ring, the ventilator, the saucer of milk, the whistle, the bed clamped to the floor.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)

Tomorrow we begin reading: The Adventure of the Speckled Band.

Teacher notes · sources: Arthur Conan Doyle Encyclopedia (https://www.arthur-conan-doyle.com/); Britannica, "Sir Arthur Conan Doyle" (https://www.britannica.com/biography/Arthur-Conan-Doyle); Arthur Conan Doyle Encyclopedia (https://www.arthur-conan-doyle.com/)

Flags (verify before teaching):

- Note for teachers: the "swamp adder" is not a real species; real snakes cannot hear whistles or climb ropes as described.

Lesson 2: The Adventure of the Speckled Band

Focus: reason defeating a hidden crime

Objective: Students will analyze how foreshadowing develops in “The Adventure of the Speckled Band” by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: CCSS RL.9-10.5, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4 · IN 9-10.RC.3, 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.9, 9-10.RC.11

Content note (murder, domestic abuse implied): Sensitive content: Murder; domestic abuse implied. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes murder; domestic abuse implied.
Suggested language: “Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?”

Teacher only · spoilers

Helen Stoner fears for her life: her twin sister Julia died two years before, crying 'It was the band! The speckled band!' Now her violent stepfather, Dr. Grimesby Roylott, has moved her into Julia's room. Holmes and Watson notice a dummy bell-rope, a ventilator and a bed bolted to the floor. They wait in the dark; Holmes strikes at a swamp adder sent through the ventilator. The snake turns and kills Roylott, who had wanted the girls' inheritance.

Background: Published in The Strand in February 1892. Doyle's Holmes popularized deductive detective fiction.

Significance: Doyle's own favorite Holmes story and a staple for teaching clues and inference.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
How do you figure out the truth when the facts seem impossible? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to violence recoils on the violent because.... Content note before we start: Heads-up: this story includes murder; domestic abuse implied.
Prompt: How do you figure out the truth when the facts seem impossible?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to violence recoils on the violent because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: Roylott dies by his own weapon.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
*Today's words: pittance — an inadequate payment; protruding — extend out or project in space; bequeathed — leave or give by will after one's death; bedrooms — a room used primarily for sleeping; impassable — incapable of being passed. “pittance”: From Middle English pitaunce, from Old French pitance, pitence, from Medieval Latin *pietāntia, from Latin pietās "piety". “bedrooms”: From bed + room.*
Words: pittance: an inadequate payment · protruding: extend out or project in space · bequeathed: leave or give by will after one's death · bedrooms: a room used primarily for sleeping · impassable: incapable of being passed

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Published in The Strand in February 1892. Doyle's Holmes popularized deductive detective fiction. Doyle's own favorite Holmes story and a staple for teaching clues and inference. Plot: Classic structure: client's story, investigation, night watch, solution. Foreshadowing: The ventilator, the bell-rope and the milk are planted early. Characterization: Roylott's violent temper (he bends a poker) contrasts with Holmes's calm. Watch for the speckled band: a misleading clue (Gypsies' scarves) that turns out to be a snake.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. “It is fear, Mr. Holmes. It is terror” (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 11). Atmosphere. That is plot at work: Classic structure: client's story, investigation, night watch, solution.

> *It is fear, Mr. Holmes. It is terror* *(The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 11)*

Think-aloud: I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. “It is fear, Mr. Holmes. It is terror” (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 11). Atmosphere. That is plot at work: Classic structure: client's story, investigation, night watch, solution.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: The repeated cry "The band! the speckled band" misleads at first; its meaning is revealed only at the end. Ask: How does this line connect to violence recoils on the violent? Expected: Roylott dies by his own weapon. (The clue.)

> *the band! The speckled band* *(The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 50)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: The repeated cry "The band! the speckled band" misleads at first; its meaning is revealed only at the end.
Ask: How does this line connect to violence recoils on the violent?
Expected answer: Roylott dies by his own weapon. (The clue.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the story for plot, foreshadowing (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about reason defeating a hidden crime? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Adventure of the Speckled Band develops the idea of reason defeating a hidden crime. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of foreshadowing and point of view shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Roylott is destroyed by the weapon he created. When the text says "Violence does, in truth, recoil upon the violent" (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 245), it shows this directly. Holmes drives the snake back, and it kills Roylott; Holmes concludes, "Violence does, in truth, recoil upon the violent."
Task: Annotate the story for plot, foreshadowing (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about reason defeating a hidden crime? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Adventure of the Speckled Band develops the idea of reason defeating a hidden crime. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of foreshadowing and point of view shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Roylott is destroyed by the weapon he created. When the text says "Violence does, in truth, recoil upon the violent" (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 245), it shows this directly. Holmes drives the snake back, and it kills Roylott; Holmes concludes, "Violence does, in truth, recoil upon the violent."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: How do you figure out the truth when the facts seem impossible? Ask: does Holmes bear any responsibility for Roylott's death?
Anchor question: How do you figure out the truth when the facts seem impossible?
Facilitation: Ask: does Holmes bear any responsibility for Roylott's death?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Story quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about reason defeating a hidden crime? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Roylott is destroyed by the weapon he created. ("Violence does, in truth, recoil upon the violent", The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 245). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about reason defeating a hidden crime? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Roylott is destroyed by the weapon he created. ("Violence does, in truth, recoil upon the violent", The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 245). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how plot shapes reason defeating a hidden crime. Key takeaway: Roylott dies by his own weapon.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Plot:** Classic structure: client's story, investigation, night watch, solution.
- **Foreshadowing:** The ventilator, the bell-rope and the milk are planted early.
- **Characterization:** Roylott's violent temper (he bends a poker) contrasts with Holmes's calm.

Themes and how they develop

- **violence recoils on the violent:** Roylott dies by his own weapon.

Symbols and motifs

- **the speckled band:** a misleading clue (Gypsies' scarves) that turns out to be a snake.

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- "It is fear, Mr. Holmes. It is terror" (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 11) Atmosphere.
- "the band! The speckled band" (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 50) The clue.
- "Violence does, in truth, recoil upon the violent" (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 245) The moral.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Roylott is destroyed by the weapon he created.
Evidence: "Violence does, in truth, recoil upon the violent" (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 245)
Reasoning: Holmes drives the snake back, and it kills Roylott; Holmes concludes, "Violence does, in truth, recoil upon the violent."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
pittance (noun)	an inadequate payment	*It is evident, therefore, that if both girls had married, this beauty would have had a mere pittance, while even one of them would cripple him to a very serious extent.*	"pittance": From Middle English pitaunce, from Old French pitance, pitence, from Medieval Latin *pietāntia, from Latin pietās "piety". (Wiktionary, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/pittance#Etymology)
protruding (verb)	extend out or project in space	*Grimesby Roylott, clad in a long gray dressing-gown, his bare ankles protruding beneath, and his feet thrust into red heelless Turkish slippers.*	

bequeathed (verb)	leave or give by will after one's death	*She had a considerable sum of money—not less than £1000 a year—and this she bequeathed to Dr.*	
bedrooms (noun)	a room used primarily for sleeping	*The bedrooms in this wing are on the ground floor, the sitting-rooms being in the central block of the buildings.*	"bedrooms": From bed + room. (Wiktionary, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/bedroom#Etymology)
impassable (adjective)	incapable of being passed	*"Yet if the lady is correct in saying that the flooring and walls are sound, and that the door, window, and chimney are impassable, then her sister must have been undoubtedly alone when she met her mysterious end."*	
revolved (verb)	turn on or around an axis or a center	*As I ran down the passage, my sister's door was unlocked, and revolved slowly upon its hinges.*	
narrowly (adverb)	closely; carefully	*In a fit of anger, however, caused by some robberies which had been perpetrated in the house, he beat his native butler to death, and narrowly escaped a capital sentence.*	"narrowly": From Middle English narowly, equivalent to narrow + -ly. (Wiktionary, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/narrowly#Etymology)
coincidence (noun)	an event that might have been arranged although it was really accidental	*"Well, there is at least a curious coincidence of dates.*	"coincidence": From Middle French coincidence (French coïncidence). By surface analysis, en + coincide + ence. (Wiktionary, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/coincidence#Etymology)
headache (noun)	a pain in the head	*"You must confine yourself to your room, on pretence of a headache, when your step-father comes back.*	"headache": From Middle English hevedeche, from Old English hēafodeċe. By surface analysis, head + ache. (Wiktionary, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/headache#Etymology)
fireplace (noun)	an open recess in a wall at the base of a chimney where a fire can be built	*"See that you keep yourself out of my grip," he snarled, and hurling the twisted poker into the fireplace, he strode out of the room.*	"fireplace": From fire + place. (Wiktionary, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/fireplace#Etymology)

Discussion questions

1. How do you figure out the truth when the facts seem impossible?
2. Where does foreshadowing appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.

3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with reason and deduction?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. Who comes to Holmes for help? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · AP: unit standards] Look for: Helen Stoner
2. What were Julia's last words? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP: unit standards] Look for: It was the band! The speckled band!
3. What strange detail does Holmes find in the room? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · AP: unit standards] Look for: A dummy bell-rope by a ventilator and a bed clamped to the floor
4. What is the 'speckled band'? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP: unit standards] Look for: A swamp adder
5. What was Roylott's motive? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · AP: unit standards] Look for: To keep the stepdaughters' inheritance
6. Retell the three most important events of “The Adventure of the Speckled Band” in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP: unit standards] Look for: Helen Stoner fears for her life: her twin sister Julia died two years before, crying 'It was the band! The speckled band!' Now her violent stepfather, Dr. Grimesby Roylott, has moved her into Julia's room. Holmes and Watson notice a dummy bell-rope, a ventilator and a bed bolted to the floor. They wait in the dark; Holmes strikes at a swamp adder sent through the ventilator. The snake turns and…
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in “The Adventure of the Speckled Band”? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · AP: unit standards] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does “The Adventure of the Speckled Band” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP: unit standards] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: “It is evident, therefore, that if both girls had married, this beauty would have had a mere pittance, while even one of them would cripple him to a very serious extent.” What does “pittance” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP: unit standards] Look for: pittance: an inadequate payment.
10. Reread: “Grimesby Roylott, clad in a long gray dressing-gown, his bare ankles protruding beneath, and his feet thrust into red heelless Turkish slippers.” What does “protruding” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP: unit standards] Look for: protruding: extend out or project in space.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does “The Adventure of the Speckled Band” suggest about reason defeating a hidden crime? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: Doyle's own favorite Holmes story and a staple for teaching clues and inference.

2. Find one example of foreshadowing in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · AP-LIT.STR] Look for: Look for hints, warnings or images that point to later events.
3. How does the point of view in this story shape what we understand about reason defeating a hidden crime? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.NAR] Look for: Look for who is telling the story and what that narrator can and cannot know.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Roylott is destroyed by the weapon he created. Useful evidence: “It is fear, Mr. Holmes. It is terror” (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 11): Atmosphere. Theme link: Roylott dies by his own weapon. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. In the passage that begins “"It is easy for me to be so, for every event of that dreadful time is seared into my memory.”, why might Doyle have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · AP-LIT.FIG] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “The Adventure of the Speckled Band”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · AP-LIT.STR] Look for: Helen Stoner fears for her life: her twin sister Julia died two years before, crying 'It was the band! The speckled band!' Now her violent stepfather, Dr. Grimesby Roylott, has moved her into Julia's room. Holmes and Watson notice a dummy bell-rope, a ventilator and a bed bolted to the floor. They…
6. As the opening story, what does “The Adventure of the Speckled Band” set up that the rest of The Adventure of the Speckled Band will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.STR] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Roylott is destroyed by the weapon he created. Useful evidence: “the band! The speckled band” (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 50): The clue. Theme link: Roylott dies by his own weapon. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.CHR] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Roylott is destroyed by the weapon he created. Useful evidence: “Violence does, in truth, recoil upon the violent” (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 245): The moral. On characterization: Roylott's violent temper (he bends a poker) contrasts with Holmes's calm. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “How do you figure out the truth when the facts seem impossible?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does plot appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with reason and deduction? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.STR] Look for: Look for key events and the causes linking them.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Roylott is destroyed by the weapon he created. Useful evidence: “It is fear, Mr. Holmes. It is terror” (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 11): Atmosphere. On plot: Classic structure: client's story, investigation, night watch, solution. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Background: Published in The Strand in February 1892. Doyle's Holmes popularized deductive detective fiction. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare ·

wait 8 s · AP-LIT.SET] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Roylott is destroyed by the weapon he created. Useful evidence: “the band! The speckled band” (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 50): The clue. Theme link: Roylott dies by his own weapon. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: “Doyle's own favorite Holmes story and a staple for teaching clues and inference.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Roylott is destroyed by the weapon he created. Useful evidence: “Violence does, in truth, recoil upon the violent” (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 245): The moral. Theme link: Roylott dies by his own weapon. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Roylott is destroyed by the weapon he created. Useful evidence: “It is fear, Mr. Holmes. It is terror” (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 11): Atmosphere. On characterization: Roylott's violent temper (he bends a poker) contrasts with Holmes's calm. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Rewrite one moment of “The Adventure of the Speckled Band” from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about reason defeating a hidden crime? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN, AP-LIT.NAR] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Roylott is destroyed by the weapon he created. Useful evidence: “the band! The speckled band” (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 50): The clue. Theme link: Roylott dies by his own weapon. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. Write three questions of your own about “The Adventure of the Speckled Band”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Roylott is destroyed by the weapon he created. Useful evidence: “Violence does, in truth, recoil upon the violent” (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 245): The moral. Theme link: Roylott dies by his own weapon. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Connect this story to greed and violence: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Doyle need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Roylott is destroyed by the weapon he created. Useful evidence: “It is fear, Mr. Holmes. It is terror” (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 11): Atmosphere. Theme link: Roylott dies by his own weapon. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Is the foreshadowing in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN, AP-LIT.STR] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Roylott is destroyed by the weapon he created. Useful evidence: "the band! The speckled band" (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 50): The clue. On foreshadowing: The ventilator, the bell-rope and the milk are planted early. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. Compare how "The Adventure of the Speckled Band" treats reason defeating a hidden crime with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Adventure of the Speckled Band see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Roylott is destroyed by the weapon he created. Useful evidence: "Violence does, in truth, recoil upon the violent" (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 245): The moral. Theme link: Roylott dies by his own weapon. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. As the final story, does this ending resolve reason and deduction? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN, AP-LIT.STR] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Roylott is destroyed by the weapon he created. Useful evidence: "It is fear, Mr. Holmes. It is terror" (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 11): Atmosphere. On foreshadowing: The ventilator, the bell-rope and the milk are planted early. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about reason defeating a hidden crime? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Roylott is destroyed by the weapon he created. Useful evidence: "the band! The speckled band" (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 50): The clue. Theme link: Roylott dies by his own weapon. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. What question would you most like to ask Arthur Conan Doyle about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Roylott is destroyed by the weapon he created. Useful evidence: "Violence does, in truth, recoil upon the violent" (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 245): The moral. Theme link: Roylott dies by his own weapon. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Foreshadowing:** look for hints, warnings or images that point to later events (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Point of view**: who is telling the story and what that narrator can and cannot know
- Also notice **Plot**: key events and the causes linking them

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who comes to Holmes for help?
   A. Julia Stoner
   B. Dr. Roylott
   C. Mrs. Hudson
   D. Helen Stoner

   Key: D (Helen Stoner)
2. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “In a fit of anger, however, caused by some robberies which had been perpetrated in the house, he beat his native butler to death, and _____ escaped a capital sentence.” Word bank: protruding, bequeathed, narrowly, pittance

   Key: narrowly
3. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What was Roylott's motive?
   A. Revenge
   B. Madness
   C. Jealousy
   D. To keep the stepdaughters' inheritance

   Key: D (To keep the stepdaughters' inheritance)
4. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 245: “_____ does, in truth, recoil upon the violent”

   Key: Violence
5. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “"Well, there is at least a curious _____ of dates.” Word bank: protruding, bequeathed, coincidence, pittance

   Key: coincidence
6. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What strange detail does Holmes find in the room?
   A. A hidden door
   B. A bloody knife
   C. A dummy bell-rope by a ventilator and a bed clamped to the floor
   D. A broken window

   Key: C (A dummy bell-rope by a ventilator and a bed clamped to the floor)
7. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “As I ran down the passage, my sister's door was unlocked, and _____ slowly upon its hinges.” Word bank: protruding, bequeathed, pittance, revolved

   Key: revolved
8. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What is the 'speckled band'?
   A. A gypsy scarf
   B. A swamp adder
   C. A necklace
   D. A ribbon

   Key: B (A swamp adder)

9. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: ""Yet if the lady is correct in saying that the flooring and walls are sound, and that the door, window, and chimney are _____, then her sister must have been undoubtedly alone when she met her mysterious end."" Word bank: pittance, impassable, protruding, bequeathed

    Key: impassable

10. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What were Julia's last words?

    A. The gypsies!

    B. The doctor did it

    C. Help me, Helen!

    D. It was the band! The speckled band!

    Key: D (It was the band! The speckled band!)

11. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of "The Adventure of the Speckled Band"?

    A. Reason defeating a hidden crime

    B. Wishes that defy fate

    C. The hunter becoming the hunted

    D. The foolishness of wishing to be young again

    Key: A (Reason defeating a hidden crime)

12. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? "the band! The speckled band" (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 50) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The clue.

13. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? "It is fear, Mr. Holmes. It is terror" (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 11) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Atmosphere.

14. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in "The Adventure of the Speckled Band"? The ventilator, the bell-rope and the milk are planted early.

    A. Personification

    B. Irony

    C. Characterization

    D. Foreshadowing

    Key: D (Foreshadowing)

15. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: Roylott is destroyed by the weapon he created. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: "Violence does, in truth, recoil upon the violent" (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 245).

    Sample answer: Holmes drives the snake back, and it kills Roylott; Holmes concludes, "Violence does, in truth, recoil upon the violent."

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the story: "Roylott is destroyed by the weapon he created." Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.

    Sample answer: Holmes drives the snake back, and it kills Roylott; Holmes concludes, "Violence does, in truth, recoil upon the violent."

17. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 11: “It is fear, Mr. _____. It is terror”

    Key: Holmes

18. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Adventure of the Speckled Band”? Classic structure: client's story, investigation, night watch, solution.

    A. Plot

    B. Irony

    C. Point of view

    D. Tone / mood

    Key: A (Plot)

19. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how violence recoils on the violent develops from an earlier story to “The Adventure of the Speckled Band”. Use one quotation from each.

    Sample answer: Roylott dies by his own weapon.

20. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “Violence does, in truth, recoil upon the violent” (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 245). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

    Sample answer: The moral.

21. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “It is fear, Mr. Holmes. It is terror” (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 11) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Atmosphere.

22. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “the band! The speckled band” (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 50) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: The clue.

23. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Grimesby Roylott, clad in a long gray dressing-gown, his bare ankles protruding beneath, and his feet thrust into red heelless Turkish slippers.”, what does “protruding” most nearly mean?

    A. an inadequate payment

    B. a room used primarily for sleeping

    C. leave or give by will after one's death

    D. extend out or project in space

    Key: D (extend out or project in space)

24. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “She had a considerable sum of money—not less than £1000 a year—and this she bequeathed to Dr.”, what does “bequeathed” most nearly mean?

    A. an inadequate payment

    B. extend out or project in space

    C. a room used primarily for sleeping

    D. leave or give by will after one's death

    Key: D (leave or give by will after one's death)

25. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “The bedrooms in this wing are on the ground floor, the sitting-rooms being in the central block of the buildings.”, what does “bedrooms” most nearly mean?

    A. an inadequate payment

    B. leave or give by will after one's death

    C. extend out or project in space

    D. a room used primarily for sleeping

    Key: D (a room used primarily for sleeping)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Middle School	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	7, 3, 17, 5, 4, 1, 8, 6, 2, 11, 13, 12, 14, 18, 15, 19	recall 9, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	9, 10, 4, 1, 6, 7, 3, 2, 11, 13, 12, 14, 15, 20, 21, 22	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	4, 6, 1, 3, 17, 7, 10, 12, 13, 11, 20, 18, 14, 15, 22, 19	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	9, 2, 6, 1, 8, 10, 11, 13, 12, 15, 14, 20, 18, 21, 19, 16	recall 6, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	9, 5, 10, 23, 24, 11, 13, 12, 18, 15, 14, 20, 21, 19, 16, 22	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Freshman	24, 17, 4, 5, 8, 13, 12, 11, 15, 14, 18, 20, 22, 19, 16, 21	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	9, 7, 3, 1, 25, 11, 13, 12, 20, 15, 14, 18, 16, 19, 22, 21	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Junior	5, 24, 3, 1, 7, 11, 13, 12, 14, 18, 15, 20, 22, 21, 16, 19	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Senior	6, 4, 17, 23, 5, 13, 12, 11, 15, 14, 18, 20, 22, 21, 19, 16	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
Graduate / PhD	7, 8, 3, 5, 23, 11, 13, 12, 18, 20, 14, 15, 21, 22, 16, 19	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; AP: see unit standards): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “The Adventure of the Speckled Band,” how does Doyle show reason defeating a hidden crime? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the foreshadowing you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; AP: see unit standards): In The Adventure of the Speckled Band, how does Doyle develop the idea of reason defeating a hidden crime? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the foreshadowing in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; AP: see unit standards): Analyze how The Adventure of the Speckled Band develops the idea of reason defeating a hidden crime. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of foreshadowing and point of view shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; AP: see unit standards): Analyze how the structure of The Adventure of the Speckled Band (where it begins, turns and ends) and its foreshadowing shape the reader's understanding of reason defeating a hidden crime. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; AP: see unit standards): Two readers disagree about what The Adventure of the Speckled Band suggests about reason defeating a hidden crime. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's foreshadowing and point of view), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; AP: AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.LAN): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Arthur Conan Doyle uses foreshadowing in The Adventure of the Speckled Band to complicate the reader's understanding of reason defeating a hidden crime. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; AP: see unit standards): Situate The Adventure of the Speckled Band within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of reason defeating a hidden crime responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; AP: see unit standards): Read The Adventure of the Speckled Band alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of reason defeating a hidden crime follows or bends those conventions, using the foreshadowing as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; AP: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Adventure of the Speckled Band and its treatment of reason defeating a hidden crime. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's foreshadowing and point of view, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; AP: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads The Adventure of the Speckled Band as evidence for a larger claim about reason defeating a hidden crime in The Adventure of the Speckled Band. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; AP: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads The Adventure of the Speckled Band as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of reason defeating a hidden crime. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Adventure of the Speckled Band.

SAT-style questions

1. *She had a considerable sum of money—not less than £1000 a year—and this she bequeathed to Dr.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “bequeathed” most nearly mean?

   A. an open recess in a wall at the base of a chimney where a fire can be built

   B. an event that might have been arranged although it was really accidental

   C. leave or give by will after one's death

   D. a pain in the head

2. *"It is easy for me to be so, for every event of that dreadful time is seared into my memory. The manor-house is, as I have already said, very old, and only one wing is now inhabited. The bedrooms in this wing are on the ground floor, the sitting-rooms being in the central block of the buildings. Of these bedrooms the first is Dr. Roylott's, the second my sister's, and the third my own. There is no communication between them, but they all open out into the same corridor. Do I make myself plain?"*

Which choice best states a central concern of "The Adventure of the Speckled Band"?

A. A girl choosing nature over a stranger's approval

B. A symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer

C. Superstition used against a credulous man

D. Reason defeating a hidden crime

SAT key: 1. C (leave or give by will after one's death); 2. D (Reason defeating a hidden crime)

Unit test

The Adventure of the Speckled Band: end test · 90 minutes · 18 questions per rigor version (multiple choice, fill in the blank, short answer). The class rigor level picks the version; student auto-adjust applies.

Short-answer scoring guides

Middle School and HS Freshman (2 points): correct answer in a complete sentence with a detail from the text. HS Sophomore to HS Senior (3 points): claim, one accurate quotation, one sentence of explanation. AP to College Sophomore (4 points): precise claim, two embedded quotations, commentary on word choice or structure, link to theme. College Junior to Graduate (5 points): nuanced thesis, close reading of two passages, synthesis across sections, a competing reading answered. Each item lists a sample answer; partial credit is described in the app.

Unit test: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What strange detail does Holmes find in the room?
   A. A hidden door
   B. A bloody knife
   C. A dummy bell-rope by a ventilator and a bed clamped to the floor
   D. A broken window

   Key: C (A dummy bell-rope by a ventilator and a bed clamped to the floor)
2. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “As I ran down the passage, my sister's door was unlocked, and _____ slowly upon its hinges.” Word bank: protruding, bequeathed, pittance, revolved

   Key: revolved
3. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 245: “_____ does, in truth, recoil upon the violent”

   Key: Violence
4. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “In a fit of anger, however, caused by some robberies which had been perpetrated in the house, he beat his native butler to death, and _____ escaped a capital sentence.” Word bank: protruding, bequeathed, narrowly, pittance

   Key: narrowly
5. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “"Yet if the lady is correct in saying that the flooring and walls are sound, and that the door, window, and chimney are _____, then her sister must have been undoubtedly alone when she met her mysterious end."” Word bank: pittance, impassable, protruding, bequeathed

   Key: impassable
6. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who comes to Holmes for help?
   A. Julia Stoner
   B. Dr. Roylott
   C. Mrs. Hudson
   D. Helen Stoner

Key: D (Helen Stoner)

7. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: ""Well, there is at least a curious _____ of dates." Word bank: protruding, bequeathed, coincidence, pittance

   Key: coincidence

8. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What was Roylott's motive?

   A. Revenge

   B. Madness

   C. Jealousy

   D. To keep the stepdaughters' inheritance

   Key: D (To keep the stepdaughters' inheritance)

9. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What is the 'speckled band'?

   A. A gypsy scarf

   B. A swamp adder

   C. A necklace

   D. A ribbon

   Key: B (A swamp adder)

10. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 11: "It is fear, Mr. _____. It is terror"

    Key: Holmes

11. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What were Julia's last words?

    A. The gypsies!

    B. The doctor did it

    C. Help me, Helen!

    D. It was the band! The speckled band!

    Key: D (It was the band! The speckled band!)

12. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? "It is fear, Mr. Holmes. It is terror" (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 11) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Atmosphere.

13. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of "The Adventure of the Speckled Band"?

    A. Reason defeating a hidden crime

    B. Wishes that defy fate

    C. The hunter becoming the hunted

    D. The foolishness of wishing to be young again

    Key: A (Reason defeating a hidden crime)

14. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? "the band! The speckled band" (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 50) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The clue.

15. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in "The Adventure of the Speckled Band"? Classic structure: client's story, investigation, night watch, solution.

    A. Plot

B. Irony

C. Point of view

D. Tone / mood

Key: A (Plot)

16. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Adventure of the Speckled Band”? The ventilator, the bell-rope and the milk are planted early.

A. Personification

B. Irony

C. Characterization

D. Foreshadowing

Key: D (Foreshadowing)

17. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: Roylott is destroyed by the weapon he created. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “Violence does, in truth, recoil upon the violent” (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 245).

Sample answer: Holmes drives the snake back, and it kills Roylott; Holmes concludes, "Violence does, in truth, recoil upon the violent."

18. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the story: “Roylott is destroyed by the weapon he created.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.

Sample answer: Holmes drives the snake back, and it kills Roylott; Holmes concludes, "Violence does, in truth, recoil upon the violent."

19. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “Violence does, in truth, recoil upon the violent” (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 245). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

Sample answer: The moral.

20. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “It is fear, Mr. Holmes. It is terror” (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 11) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

Sample answer: Atmosphere.

21. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how violence recoils on the violent develops from an earlier story to “The Adventure of the Speckled Band”. Use one quotation from each.

Sample answer: Roylott dies by his own weapon.

22. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “the band! The speckled band” (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 50) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

Sample answer: The clue.

23. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “The bedrooms in this wing are on the ground floor, the sitting-rooms being in the central block of the buildings.”, what does “bedrooms” most nearly mean?

A. an inadequate payment

B. leave or give by will after one's death

C. extend out or project in space

D. a room used primarily for sleeping

Key: D (a room used primarily for sleeping)

24. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “It is evident, therefore, that if both girls had married, this beauty would have had a mere pittance, while even one of them would cripple him to a very serious extent.”, what does “pittance” most nearly mean?

    A. leave or give by will after one's death

    B. extend out or project in space

    C. an inadequate payment

    D. a room used primarily for sleeping

    Key: C (an inadequate payment)

25. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Grimesby Roylott, clad in a long gray dressing-gown, his bare ankles protruding beneath, and his feet thrust into red heelless Turkish slippers.”, what does “protruding” most nearly mean?

    A. an inadequate payment

    B. a room used primarily for sleeping

    C. leave or give by will after one's death

    D. extend out or project in space

    Key: D (extend out or project in space)

26. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “She had a considerable sum of money—not less than £1000 a year—and this she bequeathed to Dr.”, what does “bequeathed” most nearly mean?

    A. an inadequate payment

    B. extend out or project in space

    C. a room used primarily for sleeping

    D. leave or give by will after one's death

    Key: D (leave or give by will after one's death)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Middle School	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18	recall 11, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	1, 10, 3, 8, 7, 5, 6, 2, 4, 11, 9, 14, 13, 12, 19, 17, 15, 20	recall 11, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	1, 7, 5, 4, 2, 9, 11, 10, 6, 3, 13, 12, 14, 16, 19, 15, 18, 20	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	8, 11, 6, 1, 4, 5, 10, 2, 9, 13, 12, 14, 15, 16, 17, 19, 21, 18	recall 9, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	7, 6, 1, 11, 8, 5, 2, 4, 12, 13, 14, 16, 15, 17, 19, 22, 21, 18	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	5, 23, 8, 3, 11, 24, 1, 14, 13, 12, 15, 17, 19, 16, 21, 18, 22, 20	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Freshman	7, 5, 8, 1, 11, 23, 10, 12, 13, 14, 16, 15, 17, 19, 21, 22, 18, 20	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

College Sophomore	5, 24, 10, 2, 25, 26, 23, 13, 14, 12, 16, 19, 15, 17, 20, 21, 22, 18	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Junior	25, 10, 3, 8, 6, 1, 24, 12, 14, 13, 19, 16, 15, 17, 21, 18, 20, 22	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Senior	5, 26, 3, 6, 23, 25, 24, 12, 13, 14, 19, 15, 16, 17, 21, 22, 20, 18	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
Graduate / PhD	6, 10, 8, 26, 23, 1, 7, 14, 12, 13, 15, 19, 16, 17, 21, 20, 22, 18	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

Final paper

The Adventure of the Speckled Band: final paper (formal literary analysis). Choose one prompt.

1. Analyze how Arthur Conan Doyle develops reason and deduction across The Adventure of the Speckled Band. Trace the idea through at least three moments (beginning, middle and end) and argue what the ending finally suggests.
2. Choose one recurring symbol, image or motif in The Adventure of the Speckled Band and argue how its meaning changes over the story and why that change matters to greed and violence.
3. Analyze a central character's choices in The Adventure of the Speckled Band. Argue whether the story judges that character, and how its structure or point of view shapes your answer.
4. Two readers disagree about whether The Adventure of the Speckled Band finally endorses or criticizes its society's view of protection of the vulnerable. Weigh both readings and argue for one, answering the strongest objection.

Length: Middle School 500-700 words; HS Freshman 700-900 words; HS Sophomore 900-1,100 words; HS Junior 1,000-1,300 words; HS Senior 1,200-1,500 words; AP 1,300-1,600 words; College Freshman 1,500-2,000 words; College Sophomore 2,000-2,500 words; College Junior 2,500-3,000 words; College Senior 3,000-4,000 words; Graduate / PhD 4,000-6,000 words

Evidence requirement: at least 4 quotations from at least two parts of the story. Quote the reading text exactly and cite the paragraph (MLA style). HS Senior and above: one scholarly or historical source; College Sophomore and above: two, cited in MLA.

Criterion	Points	Descriptor
Thesis	20	A specific, arguable claim that answers the prompt and organizes the paper.
Evidence	25	Well-chosen, accurately quoted and cited passages from across the work, meeting the evidence requirement.
Analysis	30	Explains how language, structure and literary elements create meaning; goes beyond summary.
Organization	15	Logical progression, clear topic sentences and transitions; introduction and conclusion frame the argument.
Style and conventions	10	Formal academic voice, present tense for literature, correct grammar and MLA format.

Essay assignments

Essay: Reason and deduction

Middle School (600 words; AP: see unit standards): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Adventure of the Speckled Band teaches about reason and deduction. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Arthur Conan Doyle develops reason and deduction in The Adventure of the Speckled Band. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Arthur Conan Doyle develops reason and deduction across The Adventure of the Speckled Band. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Adventure of the Speckled Band (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of reason and deduction. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of reason and deduction in The Adventure of the Speckled Band. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Arthur Conan Doyle's choices in The Adventure of the Speckled Band (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of reason and deduction, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Adventure of the Speckled Band's treatment of reason and deduction in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on reason and deduction in The Adventure of the Speckled Band that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on reason and deduction in The Adventure of the Speckled Band. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about reason and deduction in The Adventure of the Speckled Band, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on reason and deduction in The Adventure of the Speckled Band, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Greed and violence

Middle School (600 words; AP: see unit standards): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Adventure of the Speckled Band teaches about greed and violence. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Arthur Conan Doyle develops greed and violence in The Adventure of the Speckled Band. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Arthur Conan Doyle develops greed and violence across The Adventure of the Speckled Band. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Adventure of the Speckled Band (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of greed and violence. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of greed and violence in The Adventure of the Speckled Band. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Arthur Conan Doyle's choices in The Adventure of the Speckled Band (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of greed and violence, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Adventure of the Speckled Band's treatment of greed and violence in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on greed and violence in The Adventure of the Speckled Band that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on greed and violence in The Adventure of the Speckled Band. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about greed and violence in The Adventure of the Speckled Band, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on greed and violence in The Adventure of the Speckled Band, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Protection of the vulnerable

Middle School (600 words; AP: see unit standards): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Adventure of the Speckled Band teaches about protection of the vulnerable. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Arthur Conan Doyle develops protection of the vulnerable in The Adventure of the Speckled Band. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Arthur Conan Doyle develops protection of the vulnerable across The Adventure of the Speckled Band. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Adventure of the Speckled Band (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of protection of the vulnerable. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of protection of the vulnerable in The Adventure of the Speckled Band. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Arthur Conan Doyle's choices in The Adventure of the Speckled Band (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of protection of the vulnerable, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Adventure of the Speckled Band's treatment of protection of the vulnerable in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on protection of the vulnerable in The Adventure of the Speckled Band that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on protection of the vulnerable in The Adventure of the Speckled Band. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about protection of the vulnerable in The Adventure of the Speckled Band, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on protection of the vulnerable in The Adventure of the Speckled Band, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Original Liber et Libri curriculum. Quotations from the public-domain text. Vocabulary definitions are modern and contextual (curated; based on Princeton WordNet 3.0). Word histories appear only where verified (Online Etymology Dictionary or Wiktionary, 2026-10-20); unverified ones are left out. AP and Cambridge entries are our own summaries with links, not College Board or Cambridge text; ICC-WC and LeL IDs are Liber et Libri labels. Included with every curriculum purchase and with Classroom Pro.